



Eckert's inkwells

Lincoln liked to work in the telegraph office of the War Department while waiting for news. Here he started drafting his Emancipation Proclamation, using the desk—and inkwells—of Major Thomas Eckert.

Careful preparation

Lincoln acknowledged the good intentions behind these military efforts at emancipation, but was forced to overrule both generals' edicts. Too few people in the North were ready to consider the freeing of enslaved people as an additional Federal war aim, and a premature or partial emancipation might force one or more of the border states into seceding. Missouri, especially, was still close to the tipping point. The Supreme Court, headed by pro-slavery Chief Justice Roger Taney, was another potential problem. Taney had the power to declare a rash emancipation proclamation as unconstitutional, creating huge obstacles for the government.

Lincoln had much to consider before acting. His delays and apparent wavering enraged some members of the Republican Party in Congress, who claimed that if the president continued to prevaricate, they themselves would have to take action. They had already passed several Confiscation Acts that allowed Union generals to confiscate and use rebel property, including enslaved people.